PROGRAM DESCRIPTION

Program Strategy

Rationale for Proposed Region and Selected Core Countries: The proposed core countries for the 2023-2028 F2F Caribbean Basin Program are the Dominican Republic, Guatemala, Guyana, and Jamaica. However, POA remains flexible to work in other countries, as requested by USAID. POA has a legal presence in each proposed country. POA selected the Caribbean Basin Region for two main reasons: 1) It is a priority for the F2F Program, as the region is included in the United States (US) Farm Bill; and 2) With nearly 60 years of experience working throughout the Caribbean Basin Region, POA has developed an intimate and unique understanding of nuances in the Region's cultures and agriculture sectors. The specific core countries of the proposed program were strategically selected based on need, alignment with United States Government (USG) priorities, and opportunity to leverage efficiencies that maximize the impact of USG funding.

Strategy for Effective Use of Voluntary Technical Assistance: The F2F Caribbean Basin Program will use voluntary technical assistance to strengthen beneficiaries' climate adaptation and resilience. F2F volunteers will train hosts in climate-smart agriculture and natural resource management practices, providing tailored recommendations to sustainably increase stakeholder productivity, competitiveness, and food security. For example, a volunteer may train a Kaqchikel women's group in Guatemala in designing an intercropping system with annual and perennial crops to ensure consistent availability of fruits and vegetables for household consumption and sale. This training would not only increase the community's climate resilience, but also empower indigenous women to be leaders and key decision-makers in agriculture, specifically climate-smart agriculture.

Furthermore, F2F volunteers will train trainers to create a multiplier effect. For example, a volunteer may train Ministry of Agriculture extension agents in the Dominican Republic to install and maintain drip irrigation systems. These extension agents will then work with local farmers navigating water scarcity issues to install drip irrigation systems that maximize "crop per drop." Volunteer assistance also expands beyond on-farm production. A volunteer in Jamaica may work with the Trelawny Town Maroon Cooperative in Cockpit Country to improve dry storage of ginger and turmeric to reduce postharvest losses from increased humidity. POA will leverage the wide range of F2F volunteer technical assistance, following nine guiding principles (Table 2) to maximize impact and reach diverse stakeholders.

Proposed Approach and Planning Process

Aligning with the USAID Climate Strategy 2022-2030, and embedding considerations of gender issues and impacts, POA adopted nine guiding principles that informed the proposed approach and planning process (Exhibit 2).

Exhibit 2: F2F Caribbean Basin Approach and Planning Process: Guiding Principles

Guiding Principle	Definition
Advance Gender Equity	Provide women with equal access to technical assistance, knowledge, and innovations where household livelihoods are predominantly agriculture-based
Reduce Emissions	Catalyze urgent mitigation from energy, land use, and other key emissions sources
Build Resilience	Strengthen the resilience of populations vulnerable to climate impacts
Mobilize Finance	Increase the flow of and equitable access to finance to support adaptation

Partner with IPLCs	Partner with Indigenous peoples and local communities to lead climate action
Amplify Crucial Voices	Enable and empower women, youth, and other marginalized and/or under-represented groups to lead climate action
Transform Key Systems	Advance transformation of key systems and essential services to enhance resilience
Improve Governance	Strengthen responsive, transparent governance for effective climate action
Work Across Assistance Types	Strengthen the coordination of humanitarian, development, and peacebuilding assistance to address climate impacts

Development Goals and Objectives

Aligning with the overall F2F objectives, POA's F2F Caribbean Basin Program will seek to increase climate adaptation and resilience of vulnerable and marginalized groups in the agriculture sector. The primary goal of the F2F Caribbean Basin Program is to is to generate rapid, sustained, and broad-based economic growth in the targeted agricultural sectors of selected countries, while also focusing on critical environmental and natural resource management issues impacting agriculture sectors.

A secondary goal of the program is to increase the US public's understanding of international development issues and programs, as well as international understanding of the US and US development programs. Additionally, the F2F Caribbean Basin Program will align with the development goals and objectives defined in 1) USAID Missions' Country Development Cooperation Strategy; 2) USAID Climate Strategy 2022-2030; 3) Feed the Futures' Gender Integration Framework and Women's Empowerment in Agriculture Index; 4) USAID's Youth in Development Policy and Policy on Promoting the Rights of Indigenous People; 5) 2023 US Farm Bill; 6) US Government Global Food Security Strategy 2022-2026; and 7) Biden Administration's Executive Order on Tackling the Climate Crisis at Home and Abroad. POA will further align program activities with USAID Mission and local government priorities, and identify ways to collaborate with other USG-funded projects to maximize resources and impacts.

Expected Relationships with USAID Mission and In-Country Stakeholders:

POA prioritizes its relationship with USAID Missions and strives to complement objectives within their Country Development Cooperation Strategy (CDCS). Throughout F2F program implementation, POA regularly communicates and connects with USAID Missions to ensure that they are engaged in activities and can indicate their interests, priorities, concerns, and opportunities. F2F will also collaborate with other in-country projects to maximize the impact of USG assistance while avoiding duplication of efforts. Additionally, as detailed below, POA promotes buy-ins to USAID Missions and responds to Associate Award requests to expand F2F activities and fund projects in their areas of interest. POA also collaborates with host country governments (often the Ministry of Agriculture), local non-governmental organizations (NGOs), civil society organizations (CSOs), and private service providers. Working with and through these local stakeholders strengthens local capacity and increases human capital, laying a foundation of sustained support that hosts and beneficiaries can build on after the F2F program ends.

Responding to Requests for Associate Awards and Mission Buy-ins

POA will promote buy-ins to USAID Missions and respond to requests for Associate Awards to expand F2F activities and fund projects in their areas of interest. Buy-ins and Associate Awards may include complementary support and inputs such as equipment, grants, consultants, and volunteers. Since USAID Mission funding availability and program priorities will determine the availability of any Mission buy-ins, these are yet uncertain. If Mission funding becomes available, the Work Plan will be modified accordingly, and buy-in funding may be used for additional volunteer services or for complementary development inputs associated with and supporting the work of the F2F volunteers. For Application budgeting purposes, we have included $1,000,000 for buy-in funding as a separate line in the budget. If buy-in funding is available, implementation and targets will be increased accordingly.

Cabras para la Prosperidad (CABPRO)

POA implements the $2M CABPRO project – $1M funded by USAID/ Guatemala through the F2F buy-in mechanism and $1M private matching funds from Guatemala's Fundación Mario Lopez Estrada. CABPRO aims to improve food security and livelihoods in Guatemala's Western Highlands. The project supports 350 Indigenous Mam households to increase goat milk, poultry, egg, and vegetable production to combat chronic malnutrition and generate new economic opportunities. Over 40% of families have improved goat milk consumption, and 30% of families have increased protein consumption through poultry production. Notably, Mam women are more empowered through financial literacy skills, establishing 14 money-saving groups that have saved over $8,000 quetzals in just two months.

Addressing Gender and Environmental Concerns

Gender Concerns: POA understands that each country experiences gender disparities in different ways across different agricultural value chains. For example, in Guatemala, women face a severe gender gap in terms of access to agriculture markets and value chains. Furthermore, in rural areas, about 57% of female agricultural workers do not directly earn a salary as they are considered "helpers" to their husbands, fathers, or brothers rather than regular workers[3]. In Guyana, meanwhile, 90% of women heads of households who farm do not hold a title to their lands, making it nearly impossible to access loans to make investments in their farms.[4] To better address barriers to women's participation in different agricultural value chains across the Caribbean basin, POA will:

- Provide gender inclusion and intersectionality training to F2F field staff
- Identify, target and connect with women-led and women-focused groups across the Caribbean basin and the different value chains
- Consult and involve women as decision-makers throughout the process of designing Country F2F Projects and F2F activities
- Provide country and value chain-specific gender analysis materials to F2F Volunteers as part of the orientation process
- Conduct inclusive development analyses to assess barriers for women and other marginzalized groups.

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[3] Landa Ugarte, Ana; Salazar, Elizabeth; Quintana, Magali; Herrera, Molina Raul. USAID/Guatemala Gender Analysis Report. Prepared by Banyan Global, 2018.

[4] FAO. 2023. *Country gender assessment of the agriculture and rural sector – Guyana*. Country Gender Assessment Series. Georgetown

- Continually assess Country F2F activities and Scopes of Work (SOWs) to ensure the activities align with each core country's gender needs, risks, and inequalities
- Ensure that activities are available and accessible to women
- Ensure robust measurements of gender inclusion and indicators disaggregated by sex and intersectional identities across inputs, outcomes, and impact

Environmental Concerns: Aligning with the USAID Climate Strategy 2022-2030, the F2F Caribbean Basin Program is designed to increase climate adaptation and resilience of vulnerable and marginalized groups in the agriculture sector. Proposed Country F2F Projects aim to address specific climate threats in each country, while targeting groups that are most impacted by climate change. POA will also seek to collaborate with key government and community-level entities involved in climate and weather monitoring and modeling activities to inform F2F assignments, trainings, and share key resources with host organizations and local partners.

Inclusive Development Analyses

POA will conduct inclusive development analyses in each target country following USAID's guidance in *Suggested Approaches for Integrating Inclusive Development Across the Program Cycle and in Mission Operations*. Findings from the analyses will help identify barriers within the F2F "status quo" that can be amended to allow for greater participation from marginalized groups – for example, arranging trainings at times and with amenities that do not contribute to a burdensome workload for women.

Country F2F Project Planning

POA brings 32 years of experience in Country F2F Project planning to this award. Details are found below and in the attached work plans. POA remains flexible in developing country-level F2F Program strategies and will adjust appropriately to meet specific USAID preferences. We recognize that the final selection of countries and country F2F project areas is subject to further consultations with and no-objection from the country USAID Mission. We will consult with Missions and with the F2F AOR to finalize plans for country programs and country F2F projects and will document these in Project Work Plans approved by the Authorized Representative (AOR), and will remain flexible to revise Country Projects as necessary throughout the Life of Project (LOP).

Exhibit 3: F2F Caribbean Basin Development Objectives

Program Development Objective:	**Increase climate adaptation and resilience of vulnerable and marginalized groups in the agriculture sector**	
Country	**Country F2F Project**	**Country F2F Project Objective**
Jamaica	Climate-Smart Agriculture	Increase adaptive capacity and resilience using inclusive climate-smart agriculture practices
	Indigenous & Youth Agribusiness Development	Increase access to finance and agribusiness entrepreneurial skills among at-risk youth and Maroon populations, including women
Guyana	Climate-Smart Horticulture	Increase adaptive capacity and resilience through inclusive climate-smart fruit and vegetable production practices
	Hinterland Agribusiness Development	Increase access to finance and agribusiness entrepreneurial skills among Indigenous populations in the Hinterlands
Dominican Republic	Watershed Management	Increase resilience through sustainable livelihoods, improved practices, and enhanced watershed governance
	Border Region Livelihoods & Resilience	Increase inclusive agricultural livelihood opportunities and adaptive capacity along the DR/Haiti border
Guatemala	Nutrition-Sensitive Agriculture	Increase resilience and household nutrition through crop diversification and improved agricultural practices
	Watershed Management	Increase resilience through sustainable livelihoods, improved practices, and enhanced watershed governance

Country F2F Project Design: Based on initial assessments and reviews, the core countries proposed by POA are Guyana, Jamaica, the DR, and Guatemala, coupled with to-be-determined Flex assignments in other countries across the Caribbean Basin. As mentioned above, these proposed core countries face similar climate change risks and impacts. Each proposed Country F2F Project design addresses constraints within a specific commodity value chain, support sector, agroecological zone, geographic area, or beneficiary population (See Exhibit 2, above). These proposed Country F2F Projects align with USAID Mission strategies and objectives and draw on CDCSs, focus groups with critical public, private, and civil society stakeholders, and supplemental desk research.

Upon award, POA will complete the full analysis and design of Country F2F Projects during three months of implementation. The analysis will be based on primary and secondary research. Primary research will include stakeholder interviews with a wide range of stakeholders from select geographic areas from the public, private, and civil society sectors, including small-scale farmers, farmer organizations, agribusinesses, export-oriented processors, government officials, local NGOs, research institutes, USAID Missions, Peace Corps, and the World Bank. Secondary research will include a literature review of NGO reports, project documents, and US and host country government documents. Country Projects will be assessed in terms of whether volunteer technical assistance can achieve desired results. POA remains flexible to revise Country Projects as necessary.

As detailed in Year One Work Plan, Annex 1, POA will develop eight Country F2F Project Strategies in FY24 as quickly as possible to facilitate rapid start-up. A full LOP Work Plan is depicted in Annex 2. Prior to developing complete F2F country projects, POA will reconvene with the target country's USAID Mission and conduct a robust sector analysis, including inclusive development analyses, participatory rural appraisals, needs assessments with potential hosts, USG and host country priorities, and possible impact areas, among other factors.

A New Cohort of F2F Hosts

In the 2018-2023 program cycle, many of POA's hosts graduated from needing assistance. A select cohort of experienced F2F hosts will continue in the 2023-2028 program cycle to help expedite start-up. However, POA anticipates over 75% of hosts will be new to receiving F2F technical assistance.

Host Selection: Hosts are the foundation of an impactful F2F Program. With 32 years of experience implementing F2F Programs, POA has developed and refined its approach to selecting hosts that maximizes impact and value. POA will tap into its network of existing hosts to expedite project startup, while also seeking new motivated hosts with a willingness to learn, make improvements, and achieve sustainable results.

POA's host identification approach includes in-country networking, promoting F2F using media outreach, sub-sector consultations with local governments, and special events like agricultural fairs. POA also generates interest from prospective hosts through broad dissemination of best practices and volunteer recommendations.

POA's extensive F2F experience demonstrates that F2F success relies heavily on the selection of hosts that can learn and apply new knowledge and disseminate it to others. Hosts are selected based on criteria including: potential to show results, degree of interaction with the selected value chain or support sector, ability to identify and clearly state technical assistance needs, willingness to participate in the design of a multi-year plan with specific goals, support for the active participation of women and minority populations, use of democratic principles in operations, and commitment to supporting F2F activities. POA's hosts typically include producer groups, local NGOs, small- and medium-scale producers, agribusinesses, educational

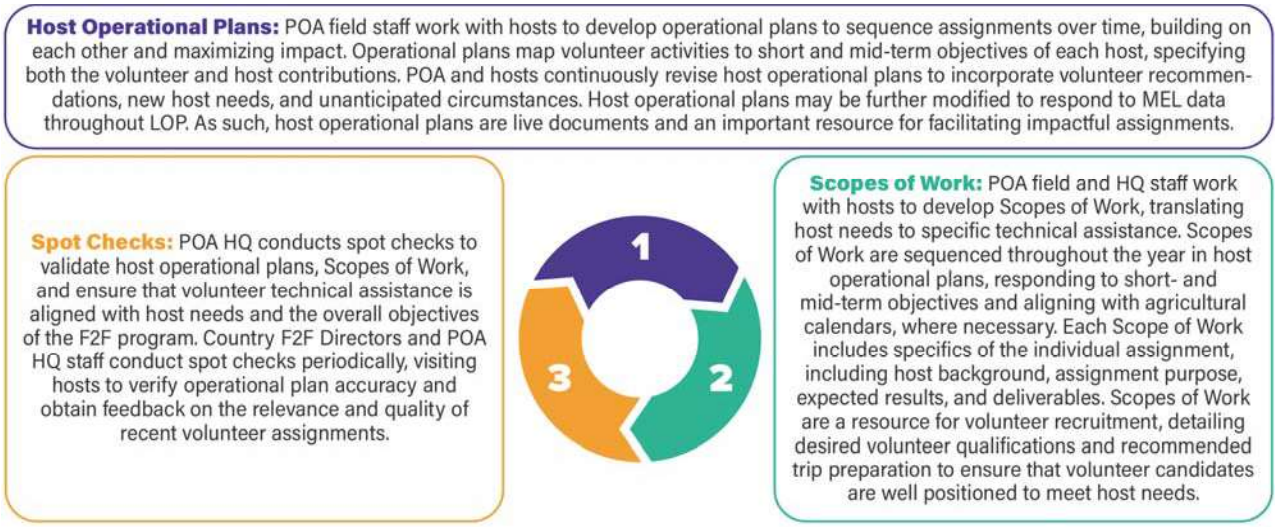
institutions, agro-processors, and marketing organizations.

With many hosts from the 2018-2023 program cycle graduating, the 2023-2028 cohort of hosts will combine a select group of experienced F2F hosts, which will expedite program activity at start-up, with intensively recruited new hosts. The new hosts, representing new geographic areas and an inclusive population subset, will make up approximately 75% of the anticipated host cohort. POA will prioritize women-led hosts, as well as Indigenous peoples, youth, and other marginalized groups in the agriculture sector.

POA recognizes the critical importance of engaging female hosts throughout F2F programming and particularly in response to changing climate and weather patterns. Despite being heavily involved in agriculture and postharvest activities, women are often more vulnerable than their male counterparts due to not having the same socioeconomic standing and opportunities. For instance, many women, in addition to securing income for their families, are tasked with providing food, water, and firewood for their households. Being stretched so thin leaves them and their children extremely vulnerable to food shortages caused by the impacts of changing climates. Research indicates, however, that female farmers and heads of households take a greater interest in climate issues and adaptation measures than males. POA targets 52% female beneficiaries and ensures that activities do not have unintended negative impacts on women.

***Host Plans*:** POA strategically selects hosts so as to work with them over several years to build their capacity in a manner that fosters sustainable positive change. Field staff and hosts work together to determine what types of assistance are needed, considering support available from other local and international programs. They develop an operational plan to sequence the assignments over time to build upon each other, maximizing efficiency and effectiveness. Operational plans contain clearly defined objectives, anticipated impact, complementary inputs that the host can provide, and volunteers' role in helping the host achieve its goals. Plans are regularly revisited, revised, and adapted to meet changing needs in dynamic, complex environments. To do this, hosts and field staff, in collaboration with other stakeholders, conduct periodic analyses of volunteer interventions, recommendations, results to date, and host goals. As the program progresses, new SOWs are identified, and hosts may request assistance in areas not previously anticipated. F2F will also work to connect hosts with complementary support.

Exhibit 4: POA's Host Assessment Process



Results Planning

POA's F2F Program will have substantive and sustainable economic impacts while focusing on gender equity and environmental sustainability. The proposed program focuses on strengthening value chains, building the capacity of local organizations, and improving resilience.

Life of Project Targets: POA has set ambitious but feasible LOP targets that maximize program outcomes and impacts while maintaining cost-effectiveness (See Annex 2). Indicators and targets will be defined upon implementation, but initial estimates are included in the attached Work Plan. In addition to standard performance and impact indicators, POA intends to develop custom indicators to better measure the unique impacts at a country and project level. Custom indicators will be developed in conjunction with Country Project Strategies during Q1. Based on initial analyses and current work, illustrative custom indicators could include the percentage of new host organizations and the percentage of indigenous persons trained. Other custom indicators may be used as a proxy to measure resilience and adaptation to climate change. POA will confirm targets for Standard F2F Program Performance and Impact Indicators in the Project Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning Plan incorporated in the Life of Project Work Plan after consultations with the USAID AOR and other F2F implementing partners.

Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning (MEL) Plan:

A critical USAID ally in developing the F2F Access Database, POA is a leader in MEL systems application for F2F. POA's existing cloud-based F2F database is designed to leverage digital solutions for MEL, including mobile data collection tools, and to facilitate complete and timely data collection, monitoring, and analysis. POA has had the opportunity to improve its F2F database and data collection tools over the years, increasing efficiency and accuracy in measuring results and enhancing organizational capacity and learning. POA will further augment its tools and capacity with new gender-inclusive approaches to data collection, such as indicators disaggregated by sex and intersectional identities.

POA's F2F Caribbean Basin Program will employ a participatory approach to MEL to promote inclusivity and sustainability and ensure F2F activities are responsive, impactful, and representative of the realities of the target communities. POA will actively engage key stakeholders—e.g., host organizations, local community members, and partners—throughout data collection and assessment activities to seek feedback and monitor results to inform decision-making and improve F2F program activities. Participatory techniques include conducting focus groups, participatory mapping, gender role analyses, and feedback and action sessions to gain valuable insights into host needs, experiences, and priorities. Through this approach, POA will ensure that the voices and concerns of diverse groups, such as women, youth, and marginalized communities, are heard and addressed throughout the life of program. Additionally, POA will promote ownership, empowerment, and inclusivity, leading to sustainable and inclusive outcomes.

Critical Implementation Issues: POA has experience responding to issues while maintaining focus on overall program objectives. A case in point is POA's response to the COVID-19 crisis. While the pandemic created many implementation challenges for F2F, it also opened the door to dynamic F2F programming, such as the remote-paired model. POA continues to apply this model even after the pandemic ended due to the its success in enabling US volunteers with limited ability to travel to participate in the program, as well as facilitating long-term virtual support to host organizations.

As described in more detail in the implementation management section below, POA's F2F

program will address critical factors such as gender equity, diversity, and environmental impact. The M&E system will capture data on these issues for monitoring and decision-making purposes.

Environment: Throughout implementation, POA will ensure compliance with USG and local environmental laws, including USAID environmental regulations regarding pesticide and/or GMO use, and comply with the F2F Program Pesticide Evaluation Report and Safer Use Action Plan (PERSUAP). In compliance with the terms of the FY24-28 Initial Environmental Examiniation for the F2F Program and of the PERSUAP, POA staff will conduct environmental screenings of individual volunteer assignments and ensure the provision of mitigation plans as indicated necessary. POA will provide environmental updates, including PERSUAP reporting, in each semi-annual and annual report. Staff will also conduct random spot checks of assignments, possibly including interviews with hosts and volunteers, across all six program countries to ensure compliance.

Gender: POA's Caribbean Basin F2F Program strategy will prioritize inclusive agricultural development, actively engaging women, youth, indigenous groups, and/or other marginalized groups throughout F2F activities. By including diverse participants, POA will provide more effective assistance and create lasting impact. POA will have a deliberate focus on addressing the specific needs and self-identified barriers of these marginalized groups, leveraging existing inclusive development analyses and conducting supplementary studies to build on existing research and data.

Public Outreach: In recent years, volunteer recommendations and other information has been widely disseminated through various avenues, including "how-to" videos posted on YouTube, radio broadcasts, and social media platforms such as Facebook and Twitter. Additionally, volunteer assignments are often coordinated to coincide with events where volunteers serve as guest speakers, which can help reach new audiences. These outreach activities not only disseminate volunteer information more widely, but also generate interest and inquiries about F2F, which is a great way to expand the program's reach in each country. The FY24-28 Program will continue leveraging lessons learned from these experiences. POA's M&E system will also measure public outreach – publications, speaking engagements, social media, etc. – as this is one of the program's goals per the Farm Bill.